

# **The Boy Who Couldn't Stop Lying**

A story about honesty, trust, and the power of truth

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

For children ages 4-10

[Illustration: Beautiful, colorful cover art depicting the main character]

## **Dedication**

To every child learning that the truth even when it's hard is always the bravest and best choice.

## Page 1

There once was a boy named Owen who discovered something strange on his seventh birthday. Every time he told a lie, a small dark shadow appeared behind him.

Nobody else could see it at first just Owen. It was small, like a dark smudge floating behind his back.

The first time it happened, Owen had told his mom he'd brushed his teeth when he hadn't. A tiny shadow popped up like a puff of smoke.

[Illustration: A young boy looking nervously over his shoulder at a small dark shadow floating behind him that no one else seems to notice, a bedroom scene with a toothbrush untouched on the sink]

## Page 2

'That's weird,' Owen thought, but he didn't worry about it much.

After all, it was just a tiny little lie. Everyone tells tiny lies, right?

The next day at school, his teacher asked who had done the homework. Owen raised his hand, even though he hadn't done it.

POOF. Another shadow appeared. Now there were two, floating behind him like dark little clouds.

[Illustration: Owen at his school desk raising his hand with a guilty expression, two small dark cloud-like shadows floating behind his chair that his classmates don't notice]

### Page 3

Owen found that lying was easy. Much easier than telling the truth.

The truth meant getting in trouble. The truth meant doing hard work. The truth meant admitting mistakes.

But lies? Lies were like shortcuts. They got him out of trouble instantly!

So Owen lied more and more. 'Yes, I cleaned my room.' 'No, I didn't eat the cookies.' 'He started it, not me!'

And with each lie, another shadow grew behind him. Three. Five. Ten. Twenty.

[Illustration: Owen walking down a hallway with a growing collection of dark shadows trailing behind him like a dark cloud, getting larger and more numerous, Owen not looking back]

## Page 4

After a few weeks, something changed. The shadows started getting bigger. They merged together into one large, dark shadow that loomed behind Owen like a storm cloud.

And now, other people were starting to notice.

'Owen, what's that behind you?' his friend Marcus asked at recess, squinting. 'It looks... dark back there.'

'Nothing!' Owen said quickly (another lie). The shadow grew a little bigger.

[Illustration: Owen at recess with a large dark shadow behind him, other children starting to notice and point, looking uncomfortable, Owen looking worried for the first time]

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The shadow began to do something terrible. It started whispering Owen's lies to the people around him.

When Owen told his teacher, 'I finished my project!' the shadow hissed, 'He didn't even start it...'

When Owen told his friend, 'Of course I'll come to your party!' the shadow whispered, 'He's not going to go...'

People couldn't hear the words clearly, but they felt something wrong. A cold, uncomfortable feeling whenever Owen spoke.

[Illustration: The dark shadow with a mouth forming behind Owen, dark wisps reaching toward the ears of people Owen is talking to, people looking uncomfortable and suspicious]

## Page 6

One by one, Owen's friends started pulling away.

'I don't know,' Marcus said when asked about Owen. 'Something about him makes me feel weird. Like I can't trust him.'

The other kids felt it too. They stopped inviting Owen to play. They chose other partners for group projects.

At lunch, the seat next to Owen was always empty now. His shadow sat there instead cold, dark, and growing.

[Illustration: Owen sitting alone at a lunch table, the dark shadow occupying the seat next to him like a companion, other kids at different tables glancing at him warily]



## Page 7

Even Owen's family noticed. When he said 'I love you' to his mom, she hugged him back but looked uncertain.

The shadow had poisoned those words too, because Owen had said so many untrue things that even his true words felt hollow now.

That was the worst part. Owen really DID love his mom. But his lies had made it so no one believed anything he said anymore.

Not even the truth.

[Illustration: Owen hugging his mother who has a worried, uncertain expression, the dark shadow looming large behind Owen, creating a visual barrier between them]

## Page 8

One night, Owen lay in bed and the shadow was so big it filled his entire room with darkness.

He couldn't see the stars through his window anymore. He couldn't feel the warmth of his nightlight.

He was surrounded by all his lies—cold, heavy, and suffocating.

'Go away!' Owen cried. But the shadow just grew thicker. It was made of HIS words, after all. It wouldn't leave until he changed them.

[Illustration: Owen in bed, his room completely dark and consumed by the shadow, trying to push it away but unable to, looking scared and alone, no light getting through]

## Page 9

The next morning, Owen went to school feeling terrible. His shadow dragged behind him like a heavy black cape.

In class, his teacher said, 'Owen, did you do last night's reading?'

Owen opened his mouth to say yes the easy lie, the comfortable shortcut.

But then he looked at the shadow. It leaned forward hungrily, waiting to be fed another lie.

And for the first time, Owen said something different. 'No,' he whispered. 'I didn't do it. I'm sorry.'

[Illustration: Owen in class with his mouth open, the shadow leaning forward eagerly, but Owen's expression changing to determination as he chooses truth, a pivotal moment]

## Page 10

Something magical happened. The moment the truth left Owen's lips, a tiny piece of the shadow dissolved.

Just a little bit like a wisp of smoke blown away by a breeze.

It was small, but Owen noticed. The truth had made the shadow shrink!

His teacher looked surprised. 'Thank you for being honest, Owen. Please do it tonight, okay?'

Owen nodded. It hadn't been easy. But something felt lighter.

[Illustration: A tiny wisp of the shadow dissolving like smoke after Owen tells the truth, a small but visible difference, Owen looking surprised and hopeful]

## Page 11

Owen decided to try again. At lunch, Marcus sat far away as usual.

Owen walked over, his massive shadow trailing behind him. 'Marcus... I lied to you about coming to your birthday party. I went to the movies instead. I'm really sorry.'

Marcus stared at him. Nobody expected Owen to admit that.

More of the shadow evaporated a big chunk this time. The truth about something that really mattered dissolved a lot more shadow than a small truth about homework.

[Illustration: Owen standing bravely in front of Marcus in the cafeteria, a large portion of his shadow dissolving as he confesses the truth, Marcus looking shocked but listening]

## Page 12

'Why are you telling me this now?' Marcus asked, arms crossed.

'Because I've been lying about everything,' Owen said. 'And it's made everyone go away. I hate it. I miss my friends. I miss being trusted.'

He took a shaky breath. 'I'm going to try to stop lying. But I might mess up sometimes. I just wanted you to know I'm trying.'

Marcus didn't smile. But he nodded slowly. 'Okay. I'll watch and see.' It wasn't forgiveness yet. But it was a door, cracked open.

[Illustration: Marcus with arms crossed but expression softening slightly, listening to Owen who looks vulnerable and honest, other kids at nearby tables watching curiously]

## Page 13

Owen spent the next week telling the truth about everything even when it was hard.

'Did you break this vase?' his mom asked. Owen wanted so badly to say no. The word was right there on his tongue.

But he looked at the shadow still big, still dark and said, 'Yes. I'm sorry. I was running inside.'

He got in trouble. He had to do extra chores. But the shadow shrank again, and his mom hugged him tight.

'I'm proud of you for telling the truth,' she said. And this time, her hug felt real and warm.

[Illustration: Owen confessing to his mother about a broken vase, looking scared but honest, his mother's expression going from stern to proud, shadow visibly shrinking behind him]

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Day by day, truth by truth, the shadow got smaller.

It wasn't easy. Sometimes the truth got Owen in trouble. Sometimes it was embarrassing. Sometimes he messed up and a small lie slipped out and a tiny shadow puff would appear again.

But Owen would catch himself, take a breath, and correct it. 'Actually, that's not true.

Let me start over.'

Each correction made the puff disappear. The shadow was shrinking steadily.

[Illustration: A sequence showing the shadow getting progressively smaller over several days, Owen standing taller and more confident each day, light returning around him]



## Page 15

The hardest truth came at school. Owen had copied from a friend's test two weeks ago. Nobody knew. He could have kept it secret. The shadow from that lie was deep and heavy. But Owen went to his teacher. 'I need to tell you something. I cheated on the last test. I copied answers.'

His teacher was disappointed. Owen had to retake the test and got a much lower grade. But a HUGE chunk of shadow dissolved. The biggest piece yet. And Owen felt lighter than he had in months.

[Illustration: Owen at his teacher's desk confessing about cheating, looking ashamed but brave, a massive piece of shadow dissolving dramatically, the teacher looking serious but respectful of his honesty]

## Page 16

Slowly, people started trusting Owen again.

It didn't happen overnight. Trust is like a tower of blocks it takes a long time to build but falls down instantly.

Owen had to prove himself with each honest word, each truthful day.

But people noticed. They could feel the darkness around Owen getting lighter.

'He seems different,' kids whispered. 'I think he's really changed.'

[Illustration: Owen in the schoolyard with other children starting to move closer to him, the shadow now much smaller, other kids cautiously approaching with curious smiles]

## Page 17

One month later, Marcus sat next to Owen at lunch again.

'You haven't lied once this whole month,' Marcus said. 'I've been watching.'

Owen smiled. 'I've been trying really hard. The truth is harder than lying, but it feels so much better.'

'Yeah,' Marcus said, unwrapping his sandwich. 'It does. Want half my cookie?'

It was a small thing sharing a cookie. But it meant everything. It meant trust was coming back.

[Illustration: Marcus sitting next to Owen at lunch again, offering half a cookie, both smiling naturally, the shadow behind Owen now very small, other kids starting to join their table]

## Page 18

By the end of the school year, Owen's shadow was almost gone.

Just the tiniest wisp remained a reminder that he'd always need to choose truth over lies.

But it no longer scared people away. It no longer whispered. It was just a tiny reminder to be honest.

Owen had his friends back. He had his family's trust back. He had himself back.

And all it had taken was the hardest, simplest thing: telling the truth.

[Illustration: Owen walking happily with friends, the shadow now just the tiniest wisp, barely visible, surrounded by laughing friends, sunshine bright around him]

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Years later, Owen became known as the most honest person in his school.

When he said something, people believed him instantly because they knew Owen always told the truth.

Sometimes younger kids asked him, 'Isn't it easier to just lie?'

Owen would smile and say, 'Lying is the easy shortcut that leads to a terrible place.

Truth is the harder road that leads somewhere beautiful.'

'Trust me,' he'd add with a wink. 'I learned the hard way.'

[Illustration: Owen as a slightly older boy, confident and trusted, surrounded by younger kids who look up to him, bright sunshine and no shadow at all, a respected and trustworthy figure]

## Page 20

Owen's little sister, Emma, came to him one day looking scared.

'Owen, I broke Mom's favorite plate. Should I tell the truth? I'm so scared of getting in trouble.'

Owen knelt down beside her. 'I know it's scary. Your stomach probably feels like it has butterflies made of rocks.'

Emma nodded, tears in her eyes. 'What if she gets really mad?'

'She might be upset,' Owen said honestly. 'But she'll be proud of you for telling the truth. And you won't have to carry a heavy shadow.'

[Illustration: Owen kneeling beside his scared little sister Emma who is holding pieces of a broken plate, Owen looking kind and wise, helping her choose honesty]

## Page 21

Together, they went to their mom. Emma was shaking, but Owen held her hand.

'Mommy, I broke your plate. I'm really sorry,' Emma said in a tiny voice.

Their mom looked at the broken plate, then at Emma's brave, trembling face.

'Thank you for telling me, sweetheart. I'm disappointed about the plate, but I'm so proud of your honesty.'

She hugged Emma tight. Owen smiled. His sister had just learned what he'd learned the hard way but she learned it much sooner.

[Illustration: Emma confessing to their mother about the plate while Owen stands supportively behind her, their mother hugging Emma, a warm family scene of truth and love]

## Page 22

At school, Owen started a project he called 'Truth Tuesday.'

Every Tuesday, his class would share one honest thing something true that was hard to say.

'I'm sorry I took your pencil without asking.' 'I actually need help with reading.' 'I feel left out sometimes.'

The classroom became a place where honesty was celebrated, not punished.

And those honest conversations built friendships deeper than anyone expected.

[Illustration: Owen's classroom on Truth Tuesday, children bravely sharing honest truths with each other, some looking nervous but supported, a circle of trust forming]



## Page 23

One day, Owen faced his hardest truth yet. His best friend Marcus asked him, 'Do you like my new haircut?'

Owen didn't love it. But the old Owen would have said something mean, and the lying Owen would have said something false.

Instead, he found the kind truth: 'I think you always look great because you're my friend.

The haircut is different, but you pull it off!'

Owen had learned something important: being honest doesn't mean being cruel. You can be truthful AND kind at the same time.

[Illustration: Owen talking to Marcus about his haircut, finding the kind truth, both boys smiling, showing that honesty and kindness can coexist beautifully]

## Page 24

The last wisp of Owen's shadow disappeared completely on a Tuesday in March. He was helping a younger kid who had been caught lying. 'I used to lie all the time,' Owen told him. 'I know how it feels.'

'Doesn't the truth ever scare you?' the little boy asked.

'Every single day,' Owen admitted. 'But I'll tell you a secret: the truth is like a muscle. The more you use it, the stronger it gets. And the lies? They're like sugar sweet in the moment but they make you sick.'

As he said those words, the last shadow puff dissolved into nothing. Owen was finally, completely free.

[Illustration: Owen talking to a younger boy on the playground, the final tiny wisp of shadow dissolving into sunshine, Owen looking completely free and light, a full-circle moment]

## Page 25

And here's the thing Owen learned that he wants YOU to know:  
Everyone is tempted to lie sometimes. It feels easier in the moment.  
But lies don't just disappear. They grow. They follow you. They push people away.  
The truth might be harder to say, but it builds something precious trust.  
And trust, once you earn it, makes every relationship in your life stronger and more beautiful than any lie ever could.

[Illustration: A final image showing Owen as a young boy looking directly at the reader with an honest, warm smile, no shadow in sight, standing in bright sunlight, a trustworthy and happy person]

## **The Moral of the Story**

### **Honesty Builds Trust; Lies Break It**

Owen learned that lies might seem like easy shortcuts, but they grow into something dark and heavy that pushes everyone away. The truth can be scary to tell, especially when you might get in trouble. But honesty builds trust and trust is the foundation of every friendship, every family, and every relationship. When people trust you, they believe in you, count on you, and want to be near you. That's worth more than any 'easy' lie.

## Discussion Questions for Parents

After reading this story together, talk about these questions:

1. Have you ever told a lie that made you feel bad afterward? What happened?
2. Why do you think people stop trusting someone who lies a lot?
3. What's the difference between a time when telling the truth is easy and when it's hard?
4. If Owen's shadow appeared behind YOUR lies, how big do you think it would be right now?
5. How can you practice being more honest, even when the truth is hard to say?

## About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a storyteller who believes every child deserves stories that spark imagination, build character, and fill hearts with wonder.

His stories are crafted to help children understand important life lessons through adventure, friendship, and the magic of imagination.

When not writing, Daniel enjoys spending time with family, exploring nature, and dreaming up new worlds for young readers to discover.

Thank you for reading! If your child enjoyed this story, please look for other books in the collection.